Nonprofit Grant Pipeline Tracker — Method Guide

How to run a grant pipeline so time goes into applications that can actually be funded, and so no report on an award you already hold is ever missed. Companion to the B12-010 workbook.

1. What this kit is

This kit is a working system for tracking grant funding from first sighting of a funder to the last report on an award. It has two parts that are meant to be used together. The workbook is where the facts live: one row per funder and program, the documents each application needs, the money you asked for and the money you were given, and every report due after an award. This guide is the method: what each field means, how the calculations behave, the order in which decisions should be made, and the mistakes that cost the most time.

The system exists because grant work fails in two specific ways. The first is effort spent on applications that were never eligible - weeks of writing that a single line of the guidelines would have prevented. The second is an award being put at risk because a report due date lived in one person's head. Both are organisational failures, not talent failures, and both are cheap to fix with a little structure.

Everything here is deliberately unglamorous. There is no discovery engine, no database of funders, no automatic alerting, and no scoring of your organisation. A pipeline is a list you keep current, a set of gates you refuse to skip, and arithmetic that does the remembering for you.

2. What this kit is not

It is not a funder directory and it does not find funding opportunities for you. It does not submit, send or file anything, and it does not communicate with any funder or portal. It contains no promise of funding, no estimate of your chances, and no claim about any specific funder's rules; those live in the funder's own guidelines, which always win over anything written here.

It is not legal, tax, accounting or fundraising advice. Eligibility, registration, matching requirements, reporting obligations and deductibility rules are governed by law and by each funder's terms. Confirm those with the funder and with your own accountant, auditor or lawyer. The workbook records what you decided; it does not decide for you.

It is also not a document management system. It records where a document lives and whether it is currently ready, with a date you last checked. The files themselves belong in your own storage, with your organisation's own access rules.

3. The one rule that saves the most time

Nothing enters Drafting until Eligibility exits clean. That single rule is the reason this workbook is stage-gated rather than a flat list. In practice, most wasted grant effort is a fully written application that was never eligible: the applicant was not the right legal entity, the service area was outside the funder's area, the award range was wrong, the match could not be documented, or a required licence had lapsed. Each of those is cheap to check in twenty minutes and expensive to discover after forty hours of writing.

This is why the Eligibility sheet is a screen of twelve must-pass questions rather than a score. A score invites negotiation with yourself - the application scores 71, so it can proceed. A screen does not: one

NO stops the application, and no other quality of the application changes that. If you take one habit from this guide, take that one.

4. The seven stages and their exit gates

The workbook's Stages sheet lists the seven stages. The important column is the exit gate: the condition that must be true before a row moves on. Movement without a satisfied gate is how a pipeline becomes fiction.

- **Research.** Exit gate: the funder's guidelines are saved and the award range overlaps what you can actually deliver. Blocked by: no saved guidelines, which means nobody can check the rules later, and a rumour about a funder standing in for the funder's own words.
- **Eligibility.** Exit gate: every must-pass question on the Eligibility sheet is answered YES for this specific application. Blocked by: partial answers, and by treating a maybe as a yes.
- **Drafting.** Exit gate: the narrative, the budget and every required document are complete, and the Docs sheet shows no MISSING for that row. Blocked by: drafting while a required document does not exist, which forces a rewrite once it does.
- **Internal review.** Exit gate: a second person has read the narrative, the budget and the numbers, and signed off. Blocked by: single-person review, which reliably finds your own assumptions rather than your own mistakes.
- **Submitted.** Exit gate: the submission confirmation or receipt is saved next to the row. Blocked by: no receipt, which means no proof of what you sent if a portal loses it.
- **Decision.** Exit gate: the award or decline letter is on file and the amount is recorded in the Awarded column. Blocked by: verbal intentions, which are not decisions and must not be treated as money.
- **Reporting.** Exit gate: every report due date is on the Timeline sheet with its cadence. Blocked by: an award letter nobody re-read, which is how a report gets missed and an award gets questioned.

Stages are not a workflow engine. Nothing in the workbook forces a row forward or refuses to let it move; the sheet tells you the stage's condition and the Dashboard tells you when something is overdue. The discipline is yours. A gate that nobody checks is decoration.

Which stage is the money stage? Reporting. Research, eligibility and drafting are how you win money; reporting is how you keep it, and it is the stage most often run from memory. If you only use one sheet regularly, use Timeline.

5. Setting up in twenty minutes

Do this once, with the funder list you already have, even if it is scribbled on paper.

■ Open Opportunities and delete the four EXAMPLE rows, or keep them until your own first four rows are in, then delete them. Yellow rows are examples, and they are not real funders.

■ Add one row per funder AND program. If the same funder runs two programs you might apply to, that is two rows: they have different deadlines, different documents and different award ranges.

■ Fill the white cells only: ID, Funder, Program, Focus area, Geography, Award min, Award max, Deadline, Status, Owner, Source URL, Next action, and later Submitted, Decision and Awarded.

■ Set Status to Research for anything you have not yet screened, and warm it through the stages as you work it.

■ On Docs, add one row per document this application needs, from the DocLibrary sheet's standard twelve. Mark Required? Y only where the funder asks for it.

■ On Budget, add the budget lines you intend to request, with the amount per line. Leave Confirmed blank until an award commits a figure.

■ On Timeline, add every post-award report with its first due date from the award letter and the gap in days. If you hold no awards yet, leave it empty - the Dashboard will simply not report on it.

Twenty minutes of setup is enough for the first five or six funders. The system gets more valuable as the list gets longer, because the questions it answers - what is due next, which application is blocked on a document, what has actually been awarded against what was asked - get harder to answer by hand.

6. Field dictionary - the Opportunities sheet

One row per funder and program. This is the spine of the workbook; every other sheet joins back to it by the ID you give each row.

- **ID** (yours to fill). Anything unique and short: a number, or a funder code. Every other sheet references this value, so never change an ID once documents and reports point at it.
- **Funder.** The exact legal name of the funding body. Use the name from the guidelines, not a nickname, so a future reader can find it without asking you.
- **Program.** The exact program or call name. Two programs at one funder are two rows.
- **Focus area.** What this program funds, in your own words, in a few words. It is your reminder of why the row exists.
- **Geography.** The area the funder serves, and - if relevant - the area you serve. This is the field that catches out-of-area applications before they are written.
- **Award min and Award max (USD).** The funder's published range. Entering this lets the row check catch an award maximum below the minimum, and later catches an awarded amount that is larger than the range you recorded, which usually means a typo or a second award.
- **Deadline.** The funder's stated closing date. Enter a real date, not text. This single field drives the days-to-deadline figure, the deadline state, the next-deadline figure on the Dashboard, and the overdue count.
- **Status.** One of Research, Eligibility, Drafting, Internal review, Submitted, Awarded, Declined, Withdrawn. Awarded, Declined and Withdrawn are the three closed states, and they are the only statuses that stop the deadline maths treating the row as live.
- **Owner.** One person's name. Not a team, not a committee. An application with no named owner is an application that will not be submitted.
- **Source URL.** Where you got the information. When a deadline is questioned six weeks later, this is the difference between a check and an argument.
- **Next action.** The next physical step, written as a verb. 'Confirm eligibility with the programme officer' is an action; 'check eligibility' is a mood.

- **Submitted.** The date you actually sent it. The row check flags Submitted status with no date, because an undated submission cannot be followed up or evidenced.
- **Decision.** The date the funder decided. Useful even when the answer was no: decision dates cluster, and a funder who has been silent past their own notification window is a funder to chase.
- **Awarded (USD).** The amount actually committed. The row check flags Awarded status with no amount, and the Dashboard compares the total here against the total you requested.

The six computed columns on this sheet are the workbook doing the remembering. Do not overwrite them: Docs ready, Docs gap, Days to deadline, Deadline state, Duplicate? and Row check. Each is explained in its own section below.

7. Field dictionary - the Docs sheet and the DocLibrary

The Docs sheet holds one row per application and document. Its two questions - is this document required by this funder, and is it ready - are separate on purpose, because they fail for different reasons and are fixed by different people.

- **Opportunity ID.** The ID from Opportunities. This is what links a document to an application.
- **Document.** The document's name, taken from the DocLibrary list where possible so the same document is not stored under four different names across applications.
- **Required? (Y/N).** Y only where this particular funder asks for it. An optional document marked required inflates the readiness figure and hides the real gaps; a required document marked optional hides a disqualifying omission.
- **Ready? (Y/N).** Y only when the file exists AND is current: signed where a signature is needed, dated within its refresh window, and matching the organisation's current numbers. 'I know where it is' is not ready.
- **Where it lives.** The folder or link. This is what turns a checklist into something a colleague can act on while you are away.
- **Last checked.** The date a human last opened it. A document ready two years ago may still be ready; a document nobody has opened may be neither ready nor current.

The DocLibrary sheet lists the standard twelve documents for a small nonprofit or a fiscally sponsored project, what each must show, and how often it needs refreshing. Use it as the source list for the Docs sheet, and edit it to match your own reality - the list is a starting point, not a rule. This is where the readiness figure on Opportunities comes from.

8. Field dictionary - the Budget sheet

One row per budget line, with the amount you requested. The sheet exists so the gap between asking and getting is visible, and so a funder's awarded amount can be compared with a real breakdown rather than a single number.

- **Opportunity ID.** Links the line to an application.
- **Line item.** The category as the funder will read it: staff, materials, evaluation, travel, administration. Use their language where you know it.
- **Requested (USD).** What you are asking for on this line. The Dashboard sums this column into total requested.

- **Confirmed (USD).** What the award letter actually committed to this line. Leave blank until then, and do not fill it with a hopeful figure.
- **Notes.** The calculation, the unit cost, or the reason the line exists. Budgets are read by people who will ask why a number is what it is.

The Dashboard's awarded-against-requested figure compares total awarded on Opportunities with total requested here. It is a management figure, not a performance metric: a low percentage across a whole portfolio may mean over-asking, or it may mean funders trimming by policy. What matters is that the figure is visible and rises or falls for reasons you can name.

9. Field dictionary - the Timeline sheet

One row per post-award report or deliverable. This is the sheet that protects money you already hold.

- **Opportunity ID.** The award this report belongs to.
- **Report or deliverable.** What the funder expects: a narrative report, a financial report, an interim update, an outcomes table, a final report.
- **First due.** The first due date, taken from the award letter or the reporting schedule. Enter a real date; leave it blank and the row tells you it needs one instead of guessing.
- **Repeat every (days).** The gap between reports, in DAYS: 30 for monthly, 90 for quarterly, 180 for half-yearly, 365 for annual. Using days rather than words removes the ambiguity of 'quarterly' across calendar years.
- **Next due.** Computed. It steps forward from the first due date in whole intervals until it lands on or after today, so it never shows a date you have already passed.
- **Status.** Computed: OVERDUE with the number of days, DUE IN with the number of days when it is within 30 days, OPEN otherwise, or CHECK INPUTS when the first due date or the cadence is missing or impossible.
- **Notes.** The template, the portal, the contact, or what the report must contain.

A blank first due date and an impossible cadence - zero, negative, or text - produce a plain instruction rather than a wrong date. This is deliberate: a report schedule that silently computes from a bad input is worse than no schedule at all.

10. How the deadline maths behaves

Three computed columns do the deadline work, and their rules are simple enough to check by hand.

Days to deadline is the deadline minus today, shown only when there is both an ID and a real date. It can be negative, and a negative number is the honest signal that the date has passed. It is blank when there is no date, rather than showing a zero that would read as 'due today'.

Deadline state turns that number into a sentence, in a deliberate order of precedence:

- If the status is Awarded, Declined or Withdrawn, the state is **CLOSED**. A closed row stops shouting about its old deadline, which is why the closed statuses matter beyond bookkeeping.
- Otherwise, if there is no deadline date, the state is **NO DEADLINE SET** - an instruction, not a blank.
- Otherwise, if the deadline is before today, the state is **OVERDUE** followed by the number of days, so the size of the problem is visible at a glance.

- Otherwise, if the deadline is within 14 days, the state is **DUE IN** followed by the number of days.
- Otherwise the state is **OPEN**.

The Dashboard's **next deadline** figure uses a separate helper column, which returns the deadline only for rows that are not closed. The minimum of that column is the next live deadline, and if every row is closed the figure is blank rather than a stale date from last year.

Why states rather than colour alone. A colour cannot be counted, sorted reliably, or read by someone who cannot distinguish it. A state string can: the Dashboard counts the rows starting with OVERDUE and the rows starting with DUE IN, and a sorted column tells you exactly what to do this week.

The one caveat. Everything here is measured against today's date on the machine that opens the file. A date is not an alarm: the workbook cannot wake anyone up, and nothing is sent anywhere. The value is entirely in the fact that the figure is correct the moment somebody looks.

11. How document readiness behaves

Two columns on Opportunities summarise the Docs sheet for each application.

Docs ready counts the required documents that are also ready, and required documents overall, and shows them as ready/required - for example 4/6. Documents marked not required are excluded from both halves, so the figure measures what this funder asked for, not everything the organisation owns.

Docs gap says MISSING the moment a single document is required and not ready, and OK otherwise. When there are no required documents recorded at all, the readiness figure reads 0/0 and the gap reads OK - honest emptiness rather than a false all-clear. The Dashboard counts the MISSING rows, which is the number that should be driven to zero before anything is submitted.

The document that most often hides. In practice, the document that blocks submission is rarely the narrative. It is the current board list, the most recent filed Form 990, the signed letter of support, or a registration renewal nobody remembered. The DocLibrary sheet lists these as their own rows precisely so they are checked early, while there is still time to obtain them, rather than in the final week.

12. How the money comparison behaves

The Dashboard reports total awarded, total requested, and awarded against requested as a percentage. The percentage is blank until something has been requested, because a fraction with a zero denominator is not information.

Two further row checks on Opportunities protect the money fields. A row with status Awarded and no awarded amount is flagged, because an award without a number is a rumour that will be counted as nothing. A row where the awarded amount is larger than the award maximum recorded for that funder is flagged too: sometimes that is a legitimate second award or a matched amount, and sometimes it is a typo in the thousands, and the flag makes a human look either way.

The workbook does not attempt to model pipelines, probabilities or expected value. Multiplying an award size by a guessed success rate produces a number that looks like a forecast and behaves like a wish. Count what is real: applications submitted, decisions received, and awards received.

13. How the reporting cadence maths behaves

The Timeline sheet computes a next due date from two numbers you supply: the first due date and the repeat interval in days. The rule is to count how many whole intervals have passed since the first due date and add them back on, never allowing a negative count, so the result is always the first due date or a later one.

Three examples show the behaviour. A first due date of 15 December with a 90-day interval, read in October, gives 15 December: no interval has yet passed, so the next report really is the first one. The same row read in January gives 15 March, because one interval has passed. A quarterly report whose first due date is in the past falls forward to the next quarter automatically, so an old award does not leave a row stuck on a date you already missed.

The status then reads OVERDUE with a day count if the computed date is behind today - which happens only when a report is genuinely late relative to its own first due date rather than to the interval - DUE IN with a day count inside 30 days, and OPEN otherwise. The Dashboard counts the overdue and the due-within-30 rows, which is the short list worth reading every week.

Why intervals in days. Monthly, quarterly and annual are periods, not dates: three months from 31 January is not a date anyone agrees on. Days are unambiguous, can be summed and compared, and are what the award letter can be translated into once.

14. Duplicate rows and the row check

Two columns keep the register honest, and both exist because the same mistakes get made every year.

Duplicate? compares each row's funder and program with every other row. If the same combination appears more than once, both rows are flagged as duplicates. This is the single most common pipeline mess: a funder gets added twice by two people, work starts on both, and the organisation submits two applications to the same program. A duplicate flag does not delete anything - only a human knows whether the second row is a genuine second application, a different program, or simply a mistake. The Dashboard counts the flagged rows.

Row check reads each row's own fields and names concrete problems in plain language: no funder name; an award maximum below the award minimum; status Submitted with no submitted date; status Awarded with no awarded amount; a missing deadline on anything that is not still at Research; an awarded amount above the range recorded for that funder. Several problems can appear in one cell, separated by full stops. A blank cell means the row has nothing obviously wrong with it - which is not the same as being correct, only as not being self-contradictory.

Both columns are read-only in practice: do not type into them. They exist so that bad data is named once, at the point it is entered, rather than discovered during a funder's verification call.

15. The eligibility screen: twelve must-pass questions

Answer these for one application, on paper, before any writing starts. One NO stops the application. If the honest answer is 'probably' or 'I think so', the answer is NO until it is confirmed in the funder's own words.

■ Is the applicant a legal entity this funder accepts - nonprofit, fiscal sponsor, school, tribe, or other eligible body?

■ Is the geographic area you serve inside the funder's stated area, as written?

■ Does your organisation size - budget band, staff count - fall inside what this funder accepts?

■ Is your program area inside this funder's stated priorities, not adjacent to them?

■ Is your registration, charity status or licence current and verifiable today?

■ Can you genuinely meet the reporting obligations you would be accepting, at the frequency stated?

■ Is your ask inside the published award range?

■ If a match or co-funding is required, can you document your share from a named source?

■ Is the deadline realistic given how many required documents are already ready?

■ Does the funder's decision timeline fit the dates your program actually needs?

■ Is there one named person who will own this application to submission?

■ If you had to reuse existing material with no rewrite at all, would you still apply?

The last question is the one people skip, and it is the most revealing. A genuine fit survives reuse with adaptation. A weak fit needs a bespoke case to be built from nothing, and that is the application that consumes three weeks and returns nothing. A NO there is not laziness; it is portfolio discipline.

Write the answer down. The Eligibility sheet has a row for each question with space for why it stops you and how to verify it. Recording the screen is what lets a colleague pick up the application, and what stops the same ineligible funder being re-added next quarter.

16. The standard document library, and what ready means

The DocLibrary sheet lists twelve documents that cover most small-organisation applications. Treat it as a checklist to edit, not a rule to obey: some funders want a logic model, some want audited statements, some want none of it.

- **Mission statement, about 150 words.** Plain language, no jargon a reviewer has to decode. Refresh annually.
- **501(c)(3) determination letter.** The IRS letter naming the organisation and its status. Filed once, on receipt.
- **EIN confirmation letter.** The IRS letter showing the employer identification number. Filed once.
- **Board of directors list.** Names, roles, affiliations and the date the list was adopted. Updated on every board change - a stale board list is one of the most common verification failures.
- **Organisation budget.** The current financial-year operating budget, board approved. Refreshed whenever the budget is approved.
- **Project budget and narrative.** Every line justified in words as well as numbers. Prepared per application.
- **Most recent Form 990.** The return as filed, not a draft. Refreshed yearly once filed.
- **Financial statements.** Audited, reviewed or internally prepared - and say which, because a reviewer will ask.
- **Program narrative.** What you do, for whom, with what evidence. Reviewed each quarter so it does not drift from reality.

- **Logic model or outcomes table.** Inputs, activities, outputs and the outcomes you actually measure.
- **Letters of support.** Dated, specific, signed, one page each. Prepared per application, and they take weeks to obtain.
- **Project timeline.** Months, milestones and who delivers them.

What ready means. Ready is not 'exists somewhere'. A document is ready when a reviewer could open it today and find it current, signed where signatures are needed, and consistent with the numbers in the rest of the application. That last test is the one that fails most often: the board list in the narrative, the budget in the attachment and the figures in the financial statements are three places for one number to disagree.

Refresh discipline. The DocLibrary sheet gives a cadence for each item. The practice that works is a single annual document review, one hour, before the busiest application season: open each document, confirm it is current, update where it is not, and set Last checked to that date. Everything after that is a checklist, not a project.

17. Writing the narrative from reusable blocks

Most of a grant narrative is organisation-wide material that changes once a year, not per application. The parts that are genuinely bespoke are the sections that respond to this funder's stated priorities, this program's design, and this budget. Separating the two is the difference between two weeks and three days of writing.

Blocks that should exist before any application is started, each one paragraph, each one already reviewed: the organisation story, the problem statement, the approach and evidence, the team, the outcomes and how you measure them, and the sustainability answer. Each block should be written to be reused, which means avoiding sentences that are true only for one funder. Keep them somewhere you control, and keep a date on each.

Blocks that must be written for each application: the response to the funder's own priorities in their own language, the specific program design and timeline, and the budget narrative. That is a bounded piece of work, and it is where the thinking belongs.

Three rules for reuse. First, never reuse a sentence that names a different funder - a leftover name is the single fastest way to lose credibility. Second, never reuse a number that has changed; pull figures from the current budget, not from the last application. Third, always re-read a reused block aloud: prose written for a different program often sounds like it, and reviewers can hear it.

On word limits. Where a funder sets a limit, respect it exactly and spend the space on their priorities, not on your history. Where there is no limit, shorter is still the discipline: a reviewer reading forty applications rewards the one that answers the question in the first sentence.

18. The budget narrative that survives review

Reviewers read the budget before they read the narrative in many small competitions, because a budget is hard to obscure. Five habits make a budget narrative defensible.

- **Every line has a unit and a count.** Staff weeks at a rate, sessions at a cost, equipment at a price. A round number with no unit invites a question you will have to answer later.

- **Administration is stated, not hidden.** If you are asking for a percentage to cover management, say so and say what it covers. A hidden overhead discovered late damages the whole application.
- **What you contribute is shown.** In-kind, volunteer time, existing staff, other funders: name them, with a value where you can defend one.
- **The totals agree everywhere.** The request total, the narrative total, the attachment total and the form field must be the same number. Prepare the budget in the workbook and copy, never retype.
- **Multi-year asks show the shape.** If the request spans years, show the split per year and what happens in each, rather than one total that implies even spending.

The Budget sheet is deliberately simple: one row per line, requested and confirmed. That simplicity is the point. Complex spreadsheets are where totals disagree; a flat list with a computed total is where they stop disagreeing. Keep the detailed workbook your finance person uses, and keep the summary here for the application.

19. Worked example: ninety days, one fictional organisation

The following is an illustration, not a real organisation, funder or result. It shows only the mechanics of the system.

A small arts organisation - call it a community arts collective with three staff and a volunteer board - starts a quarter with eleven funder rows in the register, most at Research. Over ninety days the following happens, and it is all ordinary.

- **Week 1.** The team screens all eleven against the twelve must-pass questions. Four are stopped immediately: two fund only organisations in a different service area, one requires a registration the collective does not hold, and one has an award range starting above the collective's whole programme budget. Seven remain. The four that stopped are marked Declined with the reason recorded in Next action, so nobody re-adds them next quarter - that is seventeen person-hours saved, not earned.
- **Week 2.** Documents are reviewed. The board list is two years old and names a director who left; the most recent Form 990 is missing from the folder. Both go on the Docs sheet as required and not ready for three applications at once, which is why the Docs sheet is per application rather than per organisation. The 990 is downloaded, the board list is updated and adopted, and both are marked ready with the date checked.
- **Weeks 3 to 6.** Three applications are drafted from the reusable blocks plus bespoke priority and budget sections. Two more go into Eligibility, where one is stopped on question 8 - a match requirement the collective cannot document - and one proceeds. Meanwhile a deadline on an already-drafted application moves from DUE IN 14 DAYS to DUE IN 7 DAYS on the Dashboard without anyone having to remember it.
- **Week 7.** The five live applications are submitted. Receipts are saved and the Submitted dates entered. The row check catches one row where the status had been set to Submitted a week earlier with no date, which turns out to be a submission that never completed - exactly the kind of error a memory-based system carries silently until the funder's portal closes.
- **Week 9.** Two decisions arrive. One award of 15,000 is recorded with the award letter on file; one decline is recorded with the funder's own reason copied into Next action. The award rate on the Dashboard now reads from two decisions rather than being blank. The awarded amount is entered against the budget lines that were actually funded, and the confirmed total differs from the

requested total by the amount the funder trimmed - a figure that is now visible rather than surprising the finance meeting later.

- **Week 10.** The award letter specifies four quarterly reports and a final report. Each becomes a row on Timeline with its first due date and a 90-day interval. The next due date computes to the first report, which is 57 days away.
- **Week 13.** The monthly review takes forty minutes. Two new funders are added at Research, one duplicate is found and merged (the same funder had been entered under its acronym and its full name), and the Dashboard's single next instruction is to confirm eligibility on the two new rows. Nothing is overdue, one report is due in under 30 days, and the pipeline has 9 live rows, 5 submissions, 2 decisions, 1 award.

Nothing in that quarter was clever. The value came from three ordinary behaviours: screening before writing, keeping documents current, and letting arithmetic hold the dates.

20. When you are declined: the four-line post-mortem

A decline is data if you write it down and noise if you do not. Copy the funder's own reason into the row's Next action, then write four lines somewhere you will see them again.

■ What the funder said, in their words, not your paraphrase.

■ Which stage would have caught this if it had been run properly - eligibility, documents, budget, narrative or review?

■ Whether this funder is worth a future application, and if so, what would have to change first.

■ The one thing you will do differently on the next application, written as an action.

Then close the row: set the status to Declined and record the decision date. A declined row keeps its history and stops appearing as live. What must not happen is the row being deleted. A pipeline of only live rows cannot tell you that you have applied to the same funder unsuccessfully three times, which is the single most useful thing a pipeline can tell you.

21. The monthly sixty-minute pipeline review

The system works on a monthly rhythm, and the rhythm is short on purpose. Every item below is visible on the Dashboard or one of the sheets; nothing needs to be sought out.

■ Read the Pipeline verdict first and do what it says. It is ordered by what costs least if ignored.

■ Work the overdue deadlines, newest first: an overdue application either moves or dies this month.

■ Check the rows due within 14 days and confirm each one is genuinely ready to submit - documents, budget, reviewer.

■ Clear the MISSING count: obtain or request one blocking document this month, not all of them.

■ Read the Timeline: anything overdue or due within 30 days gets a date and an owner in the calendar.

■ Add new funders at Research only. Do not start writing anything new until the live list is under control.

■ Log every decision received this month, with date, amount and the funder's reason.

■ Sweep for duplicates and row problems: both counts should be zero when you finish.

■ Write one sentence about what this month taught you. It takes thirty seconds and it is the only part that compounds.

Sixty minutes a month, plus the annual document review, is the whole maintenance burden. A pipeline that needs more attention than that is usually a sign that too many rows are live at once: five or six well-worked applications beat twenty half-worked ones, and the eligibility screen is what keeps the number honest.

22. Twenty mistakes that cost applications and awards

- Writing the narrative before screening eligibility. The most expensive mistake on this list, and the most common.
- Treating 'we could probably qualify' as a yes. A screen has no room for probably.
- Applying to funders whose award range does not overlap what you can deliver, because the money looks attractive.
- Ignoring the match requirement until the budget is written - the point at which it is no longer practical to withdraw.
- Submitting with a required document missing and promising it later. Many funders disqualify silently rather than ask.
- Using a board list that names people who have left. Reviewers check, and an inaccurate list casts doubt on everything else.
- Copying a reused narrative block that still names a different funder. It happens more often than anyone admits.
- Retyping the budget total instead of copying it, so the narrative, the attachment and the form disagree.
- Letting the deadline be remembered rather than computed, and discovering it on the closing day.
- One person writing and reviewing their own work, then submitting with their own assumptions intact.
- No named owner for an application, so every stage is everyone's job and therefore nobody's.
- Setting the status to Submitted when the work is merely finished. Submitted means a receipt exists.
- Recording a verbal 'we are likely to fund you' as an award. It can still be lost, and it must not be counted as money.
- Not recording declines, so the same ineligible funder is added again in six months.
- Not reading the award letter after a yes, and therefore not knowing what reports are now owed.
- Treating quarterly reports as a memory task, and discovering in an audit that two were never filed.
- Running the whole pipeline in one person's head and inbox while the workbook is left empty - the tool does not work unused.
- Keeping too many live applications at once, so every one of them is worked badly.
- Deleting declined rows. The history is the most useful part of a pipeline.
- Measuring activity - how many applications were sent - instead of outcomes: decisions, awards, and reports filed on time.

23. Reporting after award: the calendar that protects the money

An award is a contract with reporting obligations attached, and the obligations are usually stated in the same letter as the grant. The common cycle is: an interim report part-way through, a final narrative and financial report at the end, and for multi-year awards an annual report for each year. Some funders add site visits, outcomes data or a spend-down schedule.

Two habits prevent the failure that matters. The first is translating the schedule into a first due date and an interval on the day the award letter arrives, while the letter is open - not later, when it has gone into a folder. The second is checking the Timeline sheet weekly rather than monthly: a report due in three weeks is a task, a report due in three days is an emergency, and there is no reason to let the second state ever occur.

A missed report has a specific cost that is worse than embarrassment. It puts future funding from that funder at risk, it often triggers a closer look at the whole award, and it can require repaying an unspent or unjustified amount. The Timeline sheet exists because the cost is asymmetric: keeping it current takes two minutes a month, and a missed report can cost an award.

Close the loop at the end of an award. When the final report is filed, record the filing date in the Notes column rather than deleting the row, and set the award row's status honestly. A funder whose award is finished and reported well is the most likely source of the next award; a pipeline that keeps that history can prove it.

24. Compatibility, limitations and honest caveats

- **Spreadsheet application.** The workbook is a standard .xlsx file, built for Excel and using only common functions - COUNTIF, COUNTIFS, SUM, SUMIF, MIN, ROUNDUP, TODAY, IF, SUMPRODUCT, INDEX and MATCH - plus data validation lists. It was not verified in every spreadsheet application. If your editor changes or drops a formula or a validation list, the affected cell will say so or show an error, and the fix is to re-enter it.
- **Dynamic dates.** Anything involving today's date recalculates on open, and a file left closed for months will show stale states until it is opened again. Nothing is emailed, nothing is scheduled, and no reminder exists outside the file.
- **Sample rows.** The workbook ships with four example rows, marked EXAMPLE, so the computed columns are visible immediately. They are fictional. Delete them before real use, or the Dashboard will count them.
- **No discovery, no submission, no integration.** Nothing here finds funders, files anything, or connects to a funder portal. There is no import from a funder's own template, and no export to one beyond copying and pasting your own text.
- **The formulas are transparent, and that is deliberate.** Every computed cell can be read, and this guide explains each rule in words. If you disagree with a rule, change the formula in your copy - but change it everywhere it is used, and note the change, because the Dashboard's counts depend on the state strings in the other sheets.
- **Not advice.** Nothing in this kit is legal, tax, accounting or fundraising advice, and nothing in it is specific to any funder's requirements. Eligibility, reporting and deductibility are governed by law and by the funder's own terms.

25. Frequently asked questions

Do I need Excel, or does Google Sheets work? The file is an .xlsx workbook, and the functions used are common to both. Google Sheets import is generally reliable for these functions but it has not been tested against every version of every editor, so check the computed columns after import before relying on them.

Should I use one workbook per year, or one forever? One per year is easier to read and to archive, and it keeps the Dashboard's totals meaningful. If you carry live applications across the new year, copy those rows over rather than starting clean.

What if two people edit the workbook? Then agree on one editor at a time, or use a file in shared storage that records who changed what. The computed columns rely on the data being consistent; simultaneous edits produce duplicates and contradictions, which is exactly what the Duplicate? column will then report.

Can I add columns? Yes, anywhere to the right of the existing ones. Do not insert a column in the middle: every formula refers to columns by letter, and inserting one silently shifts what they read.

How many funders should be live at once? As many as you can genuinely work. For a small team, five or six live applications is usually the honest ceiling; the eligibility screen is what keeps the number honest rather than aspirational.

What if a deadline changes? Update the Deadline field. Everything downstream - days, state, next deadline, the overdue count - recalculates immediately. Put the funder's new notice in the Source URL or Next action so the change is dated.

What if a funder reopens the same program next year? Keep the old row, set it to Declined or Withdrawn with the reason, and create a new row for the new cycle with a new deadline. The history is worth more than the tidiness.

What if I apply for two programs at the same funder? Two rows. They have different deadlines, different documents and different award ranges, and a single row will hide one of them.

My award rate is low. What does that mean? It means decisions are being received and not all are yes. It is not automatically a problem: funders fund on their own priorities, and a portfolio with a hundred per cent award rate usually means too few, too easy, too small applications. Read the reasons recorded against declines; that is where the information is.

Why does the workbook ask whether a document is required? Because documents fail in two different ways. A document marked required that nobody can find inflates the readiness figure, and a document marked optional that the funder actually requires hides a disqualifying omission. The two questions are kept separate so both failures are visible.

The Timeline status says CHECK INPUTS. What is wrong? Either the first due date is blank or not a real date, or the repeat interval is blank, zero, negative or not a number. Fill both and the status resolves.

Can I use this for non-grant funding - sponsorship, contracts, donations? The structure fits any funding relationship with a deadline and reporting obligations, so yes, with the caveat that the eligibility questions and document list are written for grants and would need adapting.

Does it track spend against each award? Not in detail. It records what was requested and what was confirmed per budget line, and it tracks report due dates. Detailed spend tracking belongs in

accounting software, and duplicating it here would create a second set of books.

What happens if I stop using it for three months? Nothing breaks: the file shows the state as of the day it is opened. The next deadline may have passed and reports may be overdue, and the Dashboard will say so. Catching up takes one long session.

Can I share it with a board member? Yes, and a single page - the Dashboard, or the Opportunities sheet sorted by deadline - is usually what a board actually wants to see. Delete any rows containing personal contact details first if your policy requires it.

Is any of my data sent anywhere? No. The workbook is a local file with no macros, no external connections and no telemetry. Nothing leaves your machine or your storage unless you send it yourself.

26. Glossary

- **Application to a funder**: a single request under a single program, with its own deadline, documents, budget and outcome. It is one row on the Opportunities sheet.
- **Award**: a confirmed commitment of money, recorded with its amount and date. A verbal indication is not an award.
- **Award rate**: awards divided by decisions received - not by applications submitted, because silence is not yet a decision.
- **Cadence**: the repeating interval between reports, expressed in days on the Timeline sheet.
- **Closed row**: an opportunity whose status is Awarded, Declined or Withdrawn. Closed rows keep their history and stop appearing as live work.
- **Co-funding / match**: the share of a project the applicant must fund from elsewhere, which may have to be documented rather than stated.
- **Determination letter**: the IRS letter recognising an organisation's tax-exempt status; the most commonly requested proof of eligibility in the United States.
- **DocLibrary**: the sheet listing the standard twelve documents and how often each needs refreshing.
- **Docs gap**: the computed state showing that at least one required document for an application is not ready.
- **Eligibility screen**: the twelve must-pass questions answered before any writing begins.
- **Exit gate**: the condition that must be true before a row moves to the next stage.
- **Form 990**: the annual information return most US tax-exempt organisations file with the IRS; funders routinely ask for the most recent filed version.
- **Fiscal sponsor**: an organisation that provides legal and financial cover to a project that is not itself incorporated. It changes the answers to several eligibility questions.
- **Logic model**: a one-page description of inputs, activities, outputs and outcomes; often requested instead of a long narrative.
- **Next due**: the computed date of the next report, derived from the first due date and the interval, and never in the past.
- **Program**: a specific funding stream or call within a funder. Two programs at one funder are two opportunities.
- **Row check**: the computed column naming concrete problems within a single row.

- **Service area**: the geographic area a funder serves, or the area your organisation serves; the mismatch between the two is one of the most common disqualifiers.

27. First ninety minutes

■ Minutes 0-20: set up. Delete or ignore the EXAMPLE rows, add your own funders, one row per funder and program.

■ Minutes 20-40: screen. Run the twelve eligibility questions against the two or three rows you most want to work on. Stop what fails, and write the reason down.

■ Minutes 40-60: documents. Add the required documents for the surviving rows to the Docs sheet, and mark ready only what genuinely is.

■ Minutes 60-80: money. Add the budget lines you intend to request for the application you will actually write.

■ Minutes 80-90: dates. Put every live deadline in and confirm the state column reads sensibly. If you already hold an award, add its reports to Timeline now.

At the end of ninety minutes you have a screen you trust, a document list that tells you the truth, and a deadline column that will still be correct in three weeks. That is the whole system.

28. What this is not

This is a workbook and a written method for organising your own grant applications. It does not submit applications, contact funders, monitor portals, provide legal or financial advice, or promise any funding outcome. Eligibility rules, award ranges, match requirements, reporting obligations and tax treatment are set by each funder and by law, and they change; the funder's own guidelines and your own professional advisers always take precedence over anything in this kit. Review and eligibility answers shown in the examples are fictional illustrations of how the mechanics work, not statements about any real funder. The formulas are provided as a working tool and should be verified in your own copy before you rely on them.

ORGANISING TOOL ONLY - NO FUNDING IS PROMISED OR IMPLIED. Nothing here submits an application, contacts a funder, or monitors a portal. Eligibility, reporting and tax rules are set by each funder and by law - always follow the funder's own guidelines. Not legal, tax, accounting or financial advice. Examples are fictional.